

POLITICS

The presidential system of government in the Philippines has caused problems over the last few decades. In 1965, Ferdinand Marcos became president, but governed the country harshly, cheated in elections, and used his position to make a personal fortune. He was finally forced to leave when thousands of people took to the streets in protests known as "People Power," organized by the Catholic Church. In 2001 another corrupt president, Joseph

Estrada, a former film star, was also forced to step down after more mass protests from Filipinos.



ANCIENT TERRACES, MODERN METHODS

The Ifugao people have farmed the mountainous landscape in the north of Luzon island for thousands of years, laboriously constructing terraces on the steep hillsides to grow rice. These ancient terraces are now a major tourist attraction. But not all rice-growers in the Philippines use such traditional methods. The country is also home to the International Rice Research Institute, where scientists have bred new species of rice that yield more grains per plant, and are also developing rice-planting and harvesting machines.

Farmers here sow rice in the ground like any other cereal crop, rather than in a flooded paddy field.

The terraces are held in place by stone walls built entirely by hand.



RELIGION

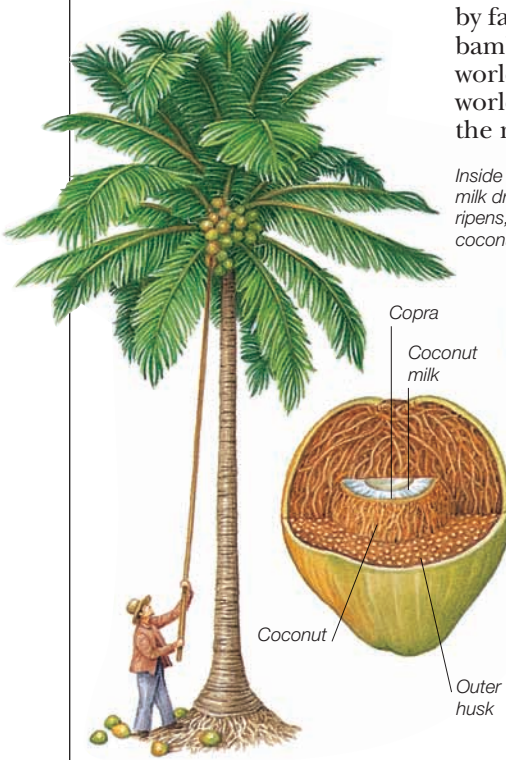
Roman Catholicism was introduced to the Philippines by the explorer Magellan, who visited the island of Cebu in 1521 during his voyage around the world. Under Spanish rule, many Filipinos converted to Catholicism. It became the major religion in all but the southern, Muslim island of Mindanao. Today, the Philippines is one of the only two Christian countries in Asia, and the Catholic Church continues to exert a powerful influence on everyday life.

Reaching a height of up to 100 ft (30 m), the coconut is one of the most beautiful palm trees in the world. Long leaves form on top of the slender trunk, and cream flowers grow on long spikes.

COCONUTS

The coconut palm flourishes in the warm, damp climate of the Philippines, producing nuts for up to 70 years. The nuts ripen in bunches of 15 to 20, and are harvested by farmers who knock them out of the trees with long bamboo poles. After Indonesia, the Philippines is the world's second largest producer of coconuts and the world's biggest producer of copra, the fleshy meat inside the nut, exporting the products around the world.

Inside the nut is a refreshing milk drink that, as the nut ripens, slowly turns into coconut meat, or copra.



101 USES OF THE COCONUT

Every part of the coconut tree has a use. The roots are turned into dyes and medicines, the trunk into lumber and charcoal, and the leaves into thatch for roofs and woven material. The nut is used for matting, food, and cosmetics.

Copra is used to make soap, cosmetics, and detergents.

Mat made from the outer husk of the coconut



HUNTER-GATHERERS

On some of the more remote islands of the Philippines live groups of hunter-gatherers, who roam the countryside fishing, hunting animals, and gathering vegetables, fruit, and berries. These people are among the last in the world to continue this ancient way of life, but their lifestyle is under attack as the forests in which they live are felled for lumber.

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